THE GEDCOM STANDARD

Release 4.0

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Prepared for
the Family History Department
(by the Projects and Planning Division)

The Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints

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This use of GEDCOM includes, but is not limited to, the following kinds of data:

- Compiled, linked genealogical records
- Original source-record extracts (such as census, probate, and vital records)
- Descriptions of sources of information
- Bibliographic records communicated internally within the Family History Department's computer systems

  GEDCOM is not to be used for exchange of bibliographic data between systems external to the Family History Department. The U. S. Library of Congress MARC (MAchine Readable Catalog) tape format for bibliographic data exchange is well established internationally, and large amounts of bibliographic data are available on magnetic tape in MARC format.

A list of the media acceptable for communication with the Family History Department is given in chapter seven, "Specification for GEDCOM Transmission Media." Media used by other communicating systems are not limited to this list.

GEDCOM is proposed as the data format of an application-layer protocol for layer seven of the Open Systems Interconnection (OSI) model. OSI is a data communication model defined by the International Standards Organization (ISO).

The User's Responsibility

Anyone desiring to use GEDCOM must be responsible for the following:

- Conversion Programs. These are necessary for converting data in a given computer to the GEDCOM format, and then back again.
- Space for Level Numbers and Tags. Each GEDCOM record requires a certain amount of space to accommodate the numbers and tags necessary for identifying information.
- Processor Time to Search for Tags within a Record. Additional time is required to find a field in a GEDCOM record.

Future Editions of the Document

GEDCOM is still new, and has not yet been exposed to demanding applications over an extended period. Changes will be made as necessary. Chapter five, "Specifications for GEDCOM Values," will be updates to include format definitions for digitized photo, audio, and video information when the need arises and the required specifications have been completed.

Suggestions and Other Correspondence

We welcome your suggestions. Please direct them to *Data Administration, Projects and Planning Division, Family History Department, 3T, Church Office Building, 50 East North Temple, Salt Lake City, UT 84150; telephone: 801-240-5227.*

Chapter 1

SPECIFICATION FOR GEDCOM LEVEL NUMBERS

Introduction

This chapter contains information you need to implement the GEDCOM level numbers.* You will find an explanation about the purpose of level numbers and how to use them when creating a transmission (a set of GEDCOM records). An example of how these numbers appear in GEDCOM lineage-linked format is shown here.

* Level	*Cross-Ref. Identifier*	*Tag*	*Value*
0		HEAD	
1		SOUR	PAF 2.1
1		DEST	ANSTFILE
0	@1@	INDI	
1		NAME	John Quentin/Doe/
1		SEX	Male
1		BIRT	
2		DATE	1836
2		PLAC	Illinois
1		DEAT	
2		DATE	24 Oct 1905
2		PLAC	Idaho Falls, Bonneville, Idaho
1		FAMS	@4@
0	@2@	INDI	
1		NAME	Mary Ann/Wilson/
1		SEX	Female
1		BIRT	
2		DATE	1838
2		PLAC	Iowa
1		FAMS	@4@
0	@3@	INDI	
1		NAME	John/Doe/
1		SEX	Male
1		BIRT	
2		DATE	11 June 1861
2		PLAC	Idaho Falls, Bonneville, Idaho
1		FAMC	@4@
0	@4@	FAM	
1		HUSB	@1@
1		WIFE	@2@
1		MARR	
2		DATE	Dec 1881
1		CHIL	@3@
0		TRLR	

The example on the preceding page is a sample transmission of genealogical information about three individuals who are members of the same family (lineage)--husband, wife, and child.

Why Level Numbers Are Used

Level numbers show how pieces (lines) of information in a GEDCOM record are related to each other. A record contains one or more lines that make up a logical grouping of information about a person, family, place, event, book, or organization, etc., or of information that identifies the transmission. To preserve the related nature of your information, you must make sure the appropriate level number appears at the beginning of each line for each record in each GEDCOM transmission.

You may send and receive a GEDCOM transmission that consists of three or more records. Each record may be a different type (for example, you may send several different records in one transmission: individual, family, header, and trailer). All you have to do is identify each record by its type, with the first tag on the first line of the record (see chapter two for more information about tags) and use appropriate level numbers for the first line and succeeding lines.

How to Use Level Numbers

An ascending numeric sequence is used for the level number. (The sequence may extend past the digits *0* through *9* if the numeric characters *10* and *up* are used.) The number is of variable length (one or more digits), and must be followed by a space. A level number is required unless the continuation option of a plus sign is used (see the CONT. tag in the appendix).

Use *0* on the first line of each record in a transmission to signal the beginning of the record (there is no value for this line; see chapter five for information about values).
Use 1 and up for the other lines to show how they relate to each other.

In the example on page 1-1, the lines at level one (1) in each record provide the information about the individual or family named in the lines at level zero (0). The lines at level two (2) identify information in the closest line at level one (1). For example, the individual record below for *John Quentin Doe* gives the date (level 2) and place (level 2) of his birth (level 1). It also gives other level *1* lines of information (for example: name and sex) for John as an individual (level 0).

Page 1-1 shows a set of lines giving information for a family. Each line contains some of the content of the record. The line containing a level number that is one number higher than the level number of the preceding line within the same record gives information about that other line, regardless of the level numbers of intervening lines.

0	@1@	INDI	
1		NAME	John Quentin/Doe/
1		SEX	Male
1		BIRT	
2		DATE	1836
2		PLAC	Illinois

Chapter 2

SPECIFICATION FOR GEDCOM TAGS

Introduction

This chapter contains information you need to implement GEDCOM tags.* You will find an explanation about the purpose of tags, how to use them when creating a transmission, and when sending and receiving information. An example of how tags appear in GEDCOM lineage-linked format is shown here.

Level	*Cross-Ref. Identifier*	*Tag	*Value*
0		HEAD	
1		SOUR	PAF 2.1
1		DEST	ANSTFILE
0	@1@	INDI	
1		NAME	John Quentin/Doe/
1		SEX	Male
1		BIRT	
2		DATE	1836
2		PLAC	Illinois
1		DEAT	
2		DATE	24 Oct 1905
2		PLAC	Idaho Falls, Bonneville, Idaho
1		FAMS	@4@
0	@2@	INDI	
1		NAME	Mary Ann/Wilson/
1		SEX	Female
1		BIRT	
2		DATE	1838
2		PLAC	Iowa
1		FAMS	@4@
0	@3@	INDI	
1		NAME	John/Doe/
1		SEX	Male
1		BIRT	
2		DATE	11 June 1861
2		PLAC	Idaho Falls, Bonneville, Idaho
1		FAMC	@4@
0	@4@	FAM	
1		HUSB	@1@
1		WIFE	@2@
1		MARR	
2		DATE	Dec 1881
1		CHIL	@3@
0		TRLR	

The example on the preceding page is a sample transmission of genealogical information about three individuals who are members of the same family (lineage)--husband, wife, and child.

Why Tags Are Used

Tags identify (classify) information in a GEDCOM record. They indicate the type of information provided by the values in the lines of a GEDCOM transmission (see chapter five for more information about values). The tags accommodate all information on a family group record, and identify individuals, families, events, dates, places, sources, etc.

In the sample transmission (page 2-1), the tag *NAME* indicates that the information in the value column, in the same line, is the name of an individual. There is a name of an individual for each of the three *NAME* tags: *John Quentin Doe*, *Mary Ann Wilson*, and *Joe Doe*.

```
1                    NAME    John Quentin/Doe/
1                    SEX     Male
1                    BIRT
2                    DATE    1836
2                    PLAC    Illinois
1                    DEAT
2                    DATE    24 Oct 1905
2                    PLAC    Idaho Falls, Bonneville, Idaho
1                    FAMS    @4@
0        @2@         INDI
1                    NAME    Mary Ann/Wilson/
1                    SEX     Female
1                    BIRT
2                    DATE    1838
2                    PLAC    Iowa
1                    FAMS    @4@
0        @3@         INDI
1                    NAME    John/Doe/
```

How to Use Tags

A tag may have any level number and appear once or many times in a GEDCOM transmission. Use the same tag for pieces of information of the same type. For example, use the *NAME* tag for the name of every individual you include in an individual or family record.

The tag is required unless the continuation option of a plus sign is used (see the CONT. tag in the appendix for a discussion of this option). The tag is of variable length (one or more characters). It is preceded by a space and followed by a *terminator* or a space (for information about the terminator, see chapter five, page 5-9).

A tag can consist of any capitalized alpha characters. Use the underscore (_) to create a tag that is more than one word: *RECORD_FILE_NUMBER*, for example.

To use a tag in a GEDCOM transmission, follow these three steps:

1. Be sure you know the following for the tag:

   - The tag name (full name)
   - The tag abbreviation (known as the tag in the transmission)
   - The tag definition

     The tag name is the full name of the tag, and varies in length. The tag abbreviation is four characters or less: PLAC for PLACE, for example. It is used in the transmission (unless the tag name is four characters or less) and is known as the tag. The tag definition designates how the tag is used in terms of what it identifies--the value in the same GEDCOM line.

2. Check the appendix for any tag you need. More than 600 tags have been defined and approved. You should find most, if not all, of the tags you need to create and send each item of information in a GEDCOM transmission. If the appendix does not contain a tag you need, you may create one and submit it for approval. Each new tag must be approved for use with GEDCOM. See the introduction to the appendix for more information about the required procedure for new tags.

3. Include all the tags needed for your transmission. Some tags are required (basic). You will want to include others (optional tags) as needed.

A List of Basic Tags

The tags for sending information about an individual and a family include basic tags that designate record types, events, dates, places, and sources. The number of tags needed for each transmission will be determined by the information you send. (For more information about individual tags, see the appendix.) Except for the header and trailer, you can send these tags in any order, as long as you preserve the data relationships (see page 2-4, last section).

- Header
- Source
- Destination
- Individual
- Name
- Sex
- Birth
- Date
- Place
- Death
- Family_Spouse
- Family_Child
- Family
- Husband
- Wife
- Marriage
- Child
- Trailer

A List of Optional Tags

Include additional, optional tags if you have information that requires them. These tags also designate information about individuals, families, record types, events, dates, places, and sources. Some also designate temple ordinances (sacred religious ceremonies performed in temples of The Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints).
(For more information about these tags, see the appendix.) Optional tags can be sent in any order. These tags include, but are not limited to:

- Age
- Address
- Adoption
- Baptism_LDS
- Burial
- Christening
- Continuation or +
- Divorce
- Endowment_LDS
- Note
- Orphan
- Reference Number
- Sealing_Child
- Sealing_Spouse
- Stake_LDS
- Submission
- Submitter
- Temple
- Type
- Ward_LDS

How to Handle Tags When Receiving a Transmission

You may send and receive tags in any order, with the exception of the header and trailer, as long as you preserve the data relationships. The order must preserve all relationships between different elements of the data. The receiving system examines a tag to determine what its line contains, and then moves the value associated with it to an appropriate field in a data base record. If the receiving system's fields require the value to be represented in a format other than the one received, the receiving system must be able to convert the data before storeing it. For example, a date may need to be changed from the day-month-year format to the month-day-year format before storage. (See chapter five for more information about format.)

You must prepare your receiving system to take care of tags that are not needed, are unexpected, occur in any order, or occur more than once with the same level number. You may have to discard a line, or store it as text in a note field. Be sure to retain the tag for possible future use.

You must also prepare your receiving system to take appropriate action when you do not receive an expected tag. For example, your system may have an internal data base field for a birth date. If you do not receive a birth date, you must set the birth date field to show that the birth date is undefined, perhaps by filling it with blanks.

Chapter 3

SPECIFICATION FOR GEDCOM TRANSMISSION HEADERS AND TRAILERS

Introduction

This chapter contains information you need to implement GEDCOM transmission header* and trailer* records. You will find an explanation of the purpose of these records, and instructions for using them in a transmission. An example of how the header and trailer records appear in GEDCOM lineage-linked format is shown here.

Level	*Cross-Ref. Identifier*	*Tag*	*Value*
0		*HEAD	
1		SOUR	PAF 2.1
1		DEST	ANSTFILE
0	@1@	INDI	
1		NAME	John Quentin/Doe/
1		SEX	Male
1		BIRT	
2		DATE	1836
2		PLAC	Illinois
1		DEAT	
2		DATE	24 Oct 1905
2		PLAC	Idaho Falls, Bonneville, Idaho
1		FAMS	@4@
0	@2@	INDI	
1		NAME	Mary Ann/Wilson/
1		SEX	Female
1		BIRT	
2		DATE	1838
2		PLAC	Iowa
1		FAMS	@4@
0	@3@	INDI	
1		NAME	John/Doe/
1		SEX	Male
1		BIRT	
2		DATE	11 June 1861
2		PLAC	Idaho Falls, Bonneville, Idaho
1		FAMC	@4@
0	@4@	FAM	
1		HUSB	@1@
1		WIFE	@2@
1		MARR	
2		DATE	Dec 1881
1		CHIL	@3@
0		*TRLR	

The example on the preceding page is a sample transmission of genealogical information about three individuals who are members of the same family (lineage)--husband, wife, and child. The lines making up the information appear between the header (HEAD) and trailer (TRLR) records.

Why Headers and Trailers Are Used

GEDCOM data format is used to transfer a wide variety of data to a wide variety of computer systems. The Family History Department's Receiving and Routing System uses header and trailer records to route the information in each GEDCOM transmission to the right place. In the sample on page 3-1, PAF 2.1 (SOUR)--the sending system--is routing the information to ANSTFILE (Ancestral File)--the destination (DEST). The names for SOUR and DEST are assigned by Data Administration in the Projects and Planning Division.

Header and trailer records may also include information to help an application software system process the data in the transmission. The header and trailer are separate from any other protocols attached to the transmission by an electronic communications network.

How to Use a Header

Use a header to begin every GEDCOM transmission. A header has both required and optional GEDCOM lines. Each line begins with a level number and a tag (in capital letters), and may be followed by a value.

Required Lines

Three different lines are required in all GEDCOM transmission headers. Each of the three required header lines from the example on page 3-1 include a level number, a tag, and a value.

Level	*Tag*	*Value*
0	HEAD	
1	SOUR	PAF 2.1
1	DEST	ANSTFILE

- HEAD. The first line of a transmission always has the level number *0* and contains the tag *HEAD*. No value is specified. All other lines in the header are at subordinate levels--level *1* in the example above.

- SOUR. The second line of a transmission always has the level number *1* and contains the tag *SOUR*. The value for the SOURce line is the resource identifier (the name of the system or file that sends the transmission), a space, and the version number of the system, if necessary. (A resource identifier is a single string of alphanumeric characters that identify any system, file, etc. that may participate in a GEDCOM transmission as either a sender or a receiver.) The value (name of the sending file) for the sample SOURce line above (see also page 3-1) is *PAF 2.1* (Personal Ancestral File, release 2.1).

  The receiving and routing function of the Family History Department associates the resource identifier with the actual locations of sender and receiver. This permits relocation of systems and files without modification of the systems that initiate transmissions, or of data containing pointers to records in other systems. The resource identifier is assigned by the Data Administration section of the Family History Department.

- DEST. The third line of a transmission always has the level number *1* and contains the tag *DEST*. The value for the *DEST*ination line is the resource identifier (the name of the system or file to which the transmission is being sent). For example, the value (name of the receiving file) for the sample DESTination line on the preceding page (see also page 3-1) is *ANSTFILE* (Ancestral File).

Optional Lines

You may include optional lines in GEDCOM transmission headers, depending on your need or preference for additional information. One or more optional lines would immediately follow the DEST line. The four optional lines shown below are possible optional lines for the sample transmission on page 3-1. They can occur in any order.

```
1    DATE    3 APR 1989
1    TIME    13:01
1    CHAR    ANSEL
1    FILE    YOUNG 00GED
```

- DATE. This line contains the date the sender generated the GEDCOM transmission. The level number for this line is *1*. The value is the date (day, month, and year) the file was created. (For more information about the value, see chapter five.)

- TIME. This line contains the time the sender generated the GEDCOM transmission. The level number for this line is *1*. The value is the time (military time) the file was created. (For more information about values, see chapter five.)

- CHAR. This line is used to change the default character set of an entire transmission to another character set. If you use this optional line, it must follow the required lines of the header (see pages 3-2 and 3-3).

  Example:

  ```
  0   HEAD
  1   SOUR   PAF 2.1
  1   DEST   ANSTFILE
  1   CHAR   ANSEL
  ```

  The level number for the *CHAR* line is *1*. The value is the name of the character set. The designation *ANSEL*, given in the example on page 3-3, is the name (value) for the GEDCOM default character set--8-Bit ANSEL. (See chapter six for more information about character sets.)

  If you use the default character set, the required lines of your GEDCOM transmission (the header and trailer) will be coded in 8-Bit ANSEL characters restricted to decimal codes 10 (line feed), 13 (carriage return), and 32 through 126 (printable characters). The characters specified will be identical to those in the 7-Bit ASCII (USA version) character set.

  If the computer you are using to send the transmission cannot accommodate the default character set, you must convert at least all required header lines to it (8-Bit ANSEL) before sending the transmission to a computer that can accommodate the default character set.

  A change of character sets, whether in the header or in the body of the data, is effective only for a single transmission. All subsequent transmissions will be in the default character set unless it is changed.

- FILE. This line contains the name of the GEDCOM transmission file generated by the sender. The level number for this line is *1*. The value is the name of the file.

How to Use a Trailer

Use a trailer to end your transmission. A GEDCOM transmission must always be terminated by *one* line containing the tag *TRLR* (trailer) with the level *0*. No value is specified for this line (see the example on page 3-1).

Chapter 4

SPECIFICATION FOR GEDCOM CROSS-REFERENCE IDENTIFIERS

Introduction

This chapter contains information you need to implement GEDCOM cross-reference identifiers.* You will find an explanation of the purpose of these identifiers and for how to use them when creating a transmission. An example of how cross-reference identifiers appear in GEDCOM lineage-linked format is shown here.

Level	*Cross-Ref. Identifier	*Tag*	*Value*
0		HEAD	
1		SOUR	PAF 2.1
1		DEST	ANSTFILE
0	@1@	INDI	
1		NAME	John Quentin/Doe/
1		SEX	Male
1		BIRT	
2		DATE	1836
2		PLAC	Illinois
1		DEAT	
2		DATE	24 Oct 1905
2		PLAC	Idaho Falls, Bonneville, Idaho
1		FAMS	@4@
0	@2@	INDI	
1		NAME	Mary Ann/Wilson/
1		SEX	Female
1		BIRT	
2		DATE	1838
2		PLAC	Iowa
1		FAMS	@4@
0	@3@	INDI	
1		NAME	John/Doe/
1		SEX	Male
1		BIRT	
2		DATE	11 June 1861
2		PLAC	Idaho Falls, Bonneville, Idaho
1		FAMC	@4@
0	@4@	FAM	
1		HUSB	@1@
1		WIFE	@2@
1		MARR	
2		DATE	Dec 1881
1		CHIL	@3@
0		TRLR	

The example on the preceding page is a sample transmission of genealogical information about three individuals who are members of the same family husband, wife, and child.

Why Cross-Reference Identifiers Are Used

Cross-reference identifiers show how one or more lines of information in a GEDCOM transmission are related. These identifiers give a unique identity to any line in a GEDCOM transmission. In the example on page 4-1, *John Quentin Doe* is related to his family in the ways shown by the cross-reference identifier *@1@* in his individual record, and by the matching pointer *@1@* in the value column in the family record.
(For more information about pointers, see chapter five, page 5-7.)

How to Use a Cross-Reference Identifier

Use a cross-reference identifier, with its associated pointer(s), to indicate a relationship between two or more lines in separate records. Make sure the pointer refers to the appropriate cross-reference identifier.

A cross-reference identifier must be unique for each transmission: it must appear only once in the cross-reference column. The pointers in the value column of the same transmission must be identical to their associated cross-reference identifier to clearly show how lines of information are related. More than one pointer can refer to the same cross-reference identifier.

In the following example (from the sample transmission on page 4-1), note how the cross-reference identifiers refer forward or backward to their associated pointers to show how John, Mary, and Joe are related as members of the same family:

Level	*Cross-Ref. Identifier*	*Tag*	Value
0	@1@	INDI	
1		NAME	John Quentin/Doe/
1		FAMS	@4@
0	@2@	INDI	
1		NAME	Mary Ann/Wilson/
1		FAMS	@4@
0	@3@	INDI	
1		NAME	John/Doe/
1		FAMC	@4@
0	@4@	FAM	
1		HUSB	@1@
1		WIFE	@2@
1		CHIL	@3@

The cross-reference identifier is optional and of variable length. Use a delimiter symbol immediately before and after this identifier. In 8-Bit ANSEL or ASCII, the delimiter is code value 64--the *at* sign (@)

You can use most alpha, numeric, or other characters to create cross-reference identifiers. You cannot, however, use the following three:

- @ (delimiter symbol)
- # (number sign, also known as the U.S. pound sign, which is code 35)
- Terminator symbol (for information about this symbol, see chapter five, page 5-9)

You can also use your computer's native keys or record numbers from its internal data base structure. Or you can use any other set of characters or symbols, as long as the cross-reference identifiers (and their pointers) are unique within a single GEDCOM transmission.

When receiving GEDCOM information, make sure your computer preserves the relationships indicated by the cross-reference identifiers and pointers (see chapter five, page 6, for information about pointers). You can do this in any way that your receiving system's data base will accommodate.

Chapter 5

SPECIFICATION FOR GEDCOM VALUES

Introduction

This chapter contains information you need to implement GEDCOM values.* You will find an explanation about the purpose of these values and how to use them when creating a transmission. An example of how they identifiers appear in GEDCOM lineage-linked format is shown here.

Level	*Cross-Ref. Identifier*	*Tag*	*Value
0		HEAD	
1		SOUR	PAF 2.1
1		DEST	ANSTFILE
0	@1@	INDI	
1		NAME	John Quentin/Doe/
1		SEX	Male
1		BIRT	
2		DATE	1836
2		PLAC	Illinois
1		DEAT	
2		DATE	24 Oct 1905
2		PLAC	Idaho Falls, Bonneville, Idaho
1		FAMS	@4@
0	@2@	INDI	
1		NAME	Mary Ann/Wilson/
1		SEX	Female
1		BIRT	
2		DATE	1838
2		PLAC	Iowa
1		FAMS	@4@
0	@3@	INDI	
1		NAME	John/Doe/
1		SEX	Male
1		BIRT	
2		DATE	11 June 1861
2		PLAC	Idaho Falls, Bonneville, Idaho
1		FAMC	@4@
0	@4@	FAM	
1		HUSB	@1@
1		WIFE	@2@
1		MARR	
2		DATE	Dec 1881
1		CHIL	@3@
0		TRLR	

The example on the preceding page is a sample transmission of genealogical information about three individuals who are members of the same family (lineage)--husband, wife, and child.

Why Values Are Used

Values provide the information specified by the tag on the same line of a GEDCOM transmission. In the example on the preceding page, *Joe*/*Doe*/ is the value specified by the tag *NAME*. Other values in other lines, such as the birth date and place, provide information about Joe Doe. The values *@3@* and *@4@*, which are pointers in four different lines, correspond to the cross-reference identifiers (*@3@* and *@4@*) in the cross-reference identifier column, showing that Joe Doe is the child on the family-record part of the transmission.

The following seven value types have been defined so far. (Other value types will be defined as the need develops.)

- *Names*--used with the NAME tag
- *Dates*--used with the DATE tag
- *Places*--used with the PLAC tag
- *Events*--used with the DEAT, BURI, BIRT, CHR, MARR, and other tags
- *Resource identifiers*--used with the SOURce and DESTination tags
- *Time*--used with the TIME tag
- *Pointers*--used with various tags

This specification explains how to record these and a few other values in lineage-linked format, to preserve relationships among the lines of information that make up a GEDCOM transmission.

Basic Guidelines for Using Values

Values are optional and of variable length. Place each value in the line with its tag. The value must appear after the space following the tag. End each value by using a terminator (see page 5-9 for information about the terminator) or by scanning the value for the number of characters specified by *length* (see page 5-9 for information about length).

The value column may consist of any alpha, numeric, or other characters, except the escape-sequence symbol (@#) and the delimiter symbol (@). If the delimiter or escape-sequence symbol needs to be sent as data, it must occur twice in succession. For example, @@ or @@# in a value column represents one @ or @# data character.

The escape-sequence symbol allows for the inclusion of specialized data forms. Currently three forms are accepted: *@#C* for character-set changes, *@#L* for data-length specification, and @#D for calendar date changes. (You will find more information on each of these at the end of this chapter.) Use the @ symbol to end the length or character-set designation. For example, a length of 30 characters is represented as *@#L30@*.